

CPC Adult Sunday Studies

Fall 2026 |

The Wonders of Communal Worship #3

The Purposes of Communal Worship

Last Week: God commands us to worship him on the Lord's Day, and we are to regulate (elements) and direct (forms) our worship according to his Word. God graciously tells us how to worship him, and wants all of his creation to sing his praises. Today, we'll expand on how the Word becomes flesh with the purpose of drawing all people into communion with himself.

HOW OUGHT GOD TO BE WORSHIPPED?

1. Doxologically - For His Glory
2. Regulated and Directed - By His Word
3. In Communion - With the Triune God who Dwells among his people
4. Covenantally - According to the Logic of the Gospel (starting next week)
5. Communally - With God's People
6. Missionally - Open to All God's People
7. In the Vernacular - In the Languages and Nations that God Created

Jesus is our Worship Leader!

Hebrews 8 - "Now the point in what we are saying is this: we have such a high priest, one who is seated at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in heaven, a minister in the holy places, in the true tent that the Lord set up, not man."

- Notice the present tense language. Insofar as we are united to Christ in worship, we are worshipping in the true, heavenly tent!
- Ps. 22 (which starts "*my God my God, why have you forsaken me?*") is quoted in Heb. 2 - "*That is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers, saying, "I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise."* (Ps.22.22) . . . " (Heb. 2.12-17). Note also Heb. 12.22-24 - "*But you have come to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem. . . "*
- **Jesus is our older brother and priest, leading us in worship!** Worship is about being united to Christ, whom we are to "*put on*" (Rom. 13.14). Notice also the constant language of "*in Christ*" throughout Paul's letters.

Remembering our redemptive-history, the paradigm for the Incarnation is the “Word became flesh” in the person of Jesus Christ. The paradigm for the Ascension is how this same Christ, reigning in heaven, is **united to his people on earth**, as “*each of us in his own native language*” (Acts 2.8) worship him “*from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages*” (Rev. 7.9) by the Spirit.

- “*We all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit.*” (2Cor. 3.18)
- How does the transcendent God come near to us? In Christ! First, as a Palestinian Jewish man, fulfilling all the Scriptures; second, still that same human, risen as Lord, uniting us to himself by the Spirit in our local culture.
 - Without this process, God remains in heaven and we have no access, judged by the standard of the law. There must be incarnation and then union to the Ascended Christ! As Calvin wrote, “as long as Christ remains outside of us, and we are separated from him, all that he has suffered and done for the salvation of the human race remains useless and of no value for us.”
 - We need both, always, to be united to Christ—just as we cannot stop being human (that’s not the goal!), our access to God is always through the God-man Jesus Christ. We can never have the left side without the right side:

God	Human
Global	Local
Objective	Subjective
Message	Medium
Truth	Love
Pilgrim	Indigenous

WORD BECOMES ALL FLESH | *For the Purpose of Communion with God in Christ through Every Culture*

The question of forms will be answered differently depending on what we think the worship service is *for*. #1 and #2 are misguided:

1. **Decisions/Revivals** - If worship is primarily like a revival, getting people to make a **decision for Christ**, then the forms will be geared toward priming people for that decision, preparing their emotions accordingly. This became the focus of the American church in the 2nd Great Awakening, specifically out of Charles Finney’s “New Measures” and the frontier revivals.

1. John Nevin, a contemporary to Finney, argued in *The Anxious Bench* that the New Measures were unchristian because they were merely outward tactics that cannot effect an inward spiritual change. **We must use forms, but the forms should not obscure the element.** One could accomplish the goals of a revival without being a Christian and without the Holy Spirit at work—excitement and decisions can be manufactured by appealing to unchristian motives (peer pressure, appeals to one's pride rather than drawing humility, emotional manipulation and confusion, trust in one's decision rather than Christ, etc.).
 1. **Conversion** is about coming to the end of yourself and trusting Christ, not emboldening one's pride in being able to make a decision. Christ is not a weak Savior, sitting back begging us to have pity upon him and choose to believe him; he is the King of Kings who reigns and has chosen to have pity upon us if we but give up our self-conceit and cast ourselves upon him—of which strength we even need him to grant!
2. **Our Duty/Work** - If worship is a **work we must now perform**, worship is something we do, out of duty, we sing, we pray for the world, the sermon is exhortative - Jesus is our example. Forms would be motivational or human-centered.
 1. In practice this is **unitarian** because it "has no doctrine of the mediator or sole priesthood of Christ, is human-centered, has no proper doctrine of the Holy Spirit, is too often non-sacramental, and can engender weariness." Leads to "Do-it-yourself", legal worship - basically Arian or Pelagian, ignoring that Christ is still human in heaven. Although it stresses the God-humanward movement in Christ, the human-Godward movement is still ours! "It is to imply that God **throws us back upon ourselves** to make our response. It ignores the fact that God has already provided for us that response which alone is acceptable to him." (James Torrance) That is, we only ever come to God **in Christ**.
3. **Communion with God in Christ by the Spirit** - If it's primarily about **communion with God for his glory**, then the forms will be according to the logic of what it means to commune with God.
 1. "The worship and mission of the church are the **gift of participating** through the Holy Spirit in the incarnate Son's communion with the Father and the Son's mission from the Father to the world."
 1. **"There is only one true Priest** through whom and with whom we draw near to God our Father. . . That is why the Reformers, in their critique of certain medieval concepts of priesthood, stressed the sole priesthood of Christ, and reinterpreted the church as a royal priesthood participating in the priesthood

of Christ." This worship "**enshrines the gospel of grace** . . . We are baptized into a life of communion." It unifies because there is only one way to come to the Father; and rather than weariness, it "releases joy and ecstasy. . . . In his love, [God] accepts us freely in the person of his beloved Son." (James Torrance, *Worship, Community and the Triune God of Grace*)

Styles and Forms for the purpose of communion - Instead of the individualistic "what would Jesus do?", we're asking "what would Jesus' body do?"

1. Bryan Chappell, *Christ-Centered Worship*, on gospel priorities, culture and mission: "First, leaders should ask, '**Who has God gathered** to do ministry in this place?' As leaders identify the mix of personalities, backgrounds, talents, and gifts God has gathered, they will begin to understand their ministry resources. . . . Second, consider the spiritual and physical needs of those **already gathered**, as well as the needs of those this *specific* church has **opportunity to reach** and serve for Christ's sake. . . . A Christ-centered church asks not only how to minister to those most like us but also how to minister to those who most need us." - How can we "deepen the church's 'rootedness' and extend her 'reach.'"?
 1. "Doxological Evangelism" - praising God is evangelistic if done in the language of the people
2. **The question for every church is "What is(are) our culture(s)?** Which parts are God-given and which are sinful? How much of our culture can stretch? What limits do we have in language, culture, style, etc.?"
 1. A perfectly multicultural church is the vision of heaven; until then, we approximate it in the current place we are in. A church in rural Indiana should look different than ours.
 2. **Notice the main questions are around *language and mission***
 1. How can we reach who we're trying to reach? What can we *expect non-Christians* we're trying to reach to be able to start with? We can't expect "too much sanctification" before heaven.
 1. If neighborhoods are segregated how does the church reach them? Some are, some aren't; some drive out of them, some don't.
 2. Compare how "porous" neighborhoods are or how "mobile" residents are in East Rock, the Hill, and Trumbull.
 1. Note the tendency for one culture to dominate another, to the point of hegemony and oppressive silence instead of indigenous empowerment.
 2. Here we're merely discussing language of a service, not to mention the rest of community life!